

drives, no laptops, the only thing you need wherever you go is the internet, and you can start working.

Guess what each and every one of them has in common? AJAX! AJAX in a way, is the spirit of the web.

Often times you will notice that some AJAX-based web sites take a long time to load, and this has been often cited as a big flaw, however the fact is that once the web site loads, it covers up for lost time pretty quick. If you use Gmail, try comparing its working in 'Standard' mode and 'basic HTML' mode. You will realise that although it loads much faster in 'basic HTML' mode, it takes much longer to open an email, switch folders etc as the page is refreshed every time. Functionality such as chatting in the browser, Web Clips etc. are also not available. The interface itself seems like a dull reminder of archaic times.

5.2 Starting AJAX coding

Since AJAX isn't really a language, there is no such thing as pure AJAX code. As such what we will learn now will be JavaScript code which uses the principles of AJAX.

You have learnt JavaScript, HTML, and XML in the previous sections, and here we will use all three. So if you tried to cheat by skipping straight to the juicy AJAXy bits of this book, beware! There is little chance you will learn anything here if you aren't already acquainted with those topics. Turn back now.

One of the features that is most used in AJAX is the XMLHttpRequest object, so let us begin with that. XMLHttpRequest is a JavaScript object that allows you to load data from a server at any time. Using XMLHttpRequest, you can be in control of when the data of the page is loaded instead of waiting for a user to click on a link. You can create an XMLHttpRequest object at any time, and use it to initiate a connection to a remote server. You can then load data from this server, and using JavaScript place it on your page after it has loaded.

The first hurdle we encounter while using XMLHttpRequest is browser compatibility. Quite a few people out there are still using older versions of Internet Explorer which require a spe-